affected, truly understanding their pain and the ground impact of measures which were undertaken then. One of my big takeaways then was noticing that devastation brought about immense food insecurity amongst grieving folks who had survived. All these experiences remain etched in my memory and looking back, I certainly feel that they do contribute to the decisions I make today—take for instance, the free food grains assistance programme which we started right from the beginning of the pandemic and remains ongoing as we speak.'

'Mr Prime Minister, how do you find strength to deal with the tough days?' I enquired.

'You see, I have a big appetite for risk. I don't believe in religious rituals but find immense strength in spirituality. Having said that, I certainly understand the power of religious rituals and why the path of Bhakti yoga, which is prescribed in the Bhagavad Gita as one of the paths to salvation, is adopted by many. I find great strength in connecting with individuals. In my decades of public life, I have travelled through the nooks and corners of India where I've met with countless people and have managed to stay in touch with them. When the pandemic struck, all my meetings became virtual and I had some time on my hands. To better utilize this time, I would sit by myself and think of the various people I have encountered in my life, especially those who may be senior citizens. I'd imagine how life would have changed for them due to the pandemic and almost make a mental picture of their current circumstances. These people included farmers, grocers, mechanics, businessmen, karyakartas [party workers] and social service workers, amongst others. After a few days, I'd call those folks up and enquire about their well-being. Shocked that the prime minister is calling them at a time of crisis, they'd more often than not tell me they were well and how some initiatives that our government had announced were benefitting them. They'd also encourage me to go on and continue to work harder to ensure that India remained safe and not worry about them. The similarities which I found between the mental pictures I had made of them and their realities in addition to the emotional bond I'd build with them would give me immense strength to bring in more initiatives for easing lives. Similarly, I called up the leaders of the 50 most underdeveloped countries in the world assuring them that India was standing by them in this time of global crisis. Many of them found strength in the fact that an Indian